Muslim give you assurance, I as an Afghan give you assurance, that we are with you and we will never betray you'.[34] When quizzed by India, Kabul backtracked, but the diplomatic damage was done. Perceptions about Afghanistan's lack of support to India, or a 'rupture' in India-Afghanistan relations during the 1965 war, persist.[35] According to retired Indian diplomat Chinmaya Gharekhan, who became the PM's special representative to the Middle East (2005–09), 'Afghanistan never sided with India in India's disputes with Pakistan. Afghanistan voted against Pakistan's membership in the UN ... but on issues like Kashmir, especially Kashmir, we [India] have not had any support from Afghanistan'.[36] J. N. Dixit, a powerful Indian diplomat who enjoyed Indira, Rajiv, as well as Sonia Gandhi's confidence and went on to become NSA in 2005, held similar views, i.e. Zahir Shah, 'was ambiguous about Indo-Pakistan relations [and] was not supportive of India in its conflicts with Pakistan in 1947–49, 1965, and 1971', and 'equivocated' on Kashmir.[37]

Though Zahir Shah did not support India over Pakistan directly, he did not oppose India either. Walking a tightrope in highly tense situations, Kabul saw it in its best interests to be, or be seen as being, neutral. India's military assault on Lahore raised concerns in Kabul about a potential unraveling of Pakistan. In this context, as India's advocacy on Pashtunistan gained momentum, Kabul began down-playing the issue in bilateral exchanges with Pakistan. On 30 September 1965, few days after hostilities between India and Pakistan ended, Rawan Farhadi, director-general for political affairs and the senior most official in Afghanistan's ministry of foreign affairs, informed the US diplomat in Kabul, William F. Spengler, that Kabul's strategic restraint on Pashtunistan during the war had developed enough goodwill in Pakistan to start talks on the bilateral dispute.[38] Instead of pressing for territorial revision, Kabul would endorse more autonomy to Pashtuns within Pakistan, Farhadi asserted. While the specifics of such a dialogue were not outlined (given Pakistan's refusal to entertain Afghan gestures), Kabul tried using the war to resolve the Pashtunistan issue by dialogue rather than force.

Concerned about the AIR broadcasts of increased Pashtun activism against Pakistan, Farhadi maintained the Afghan media had been nearly 'silent' on the issue, and denied that the AIR had picked up such information from Afghan